

First 10 Steps to Win Government Contracts

A practical roadmap for small businesses entering the federal contracting marketplace.

1 Obtain Your UEI (Unique Entity Identifier)

The UEI replaced the DUNS number in 2022. Register at [SAM.gov](https://sam.gov) — it's free and required before any federal contracting activity.

■ *Key resource: sam.gov — free, allow 1–3 business days*

2 Register in SAM.gov

The System for Award Management is the federal government's primary vendor database. Active registration is mandatory to bid. Renew annually — a lapsed registration disqualifies your bids.

■ *Warning: Third-party sites charge fees — always register directly at [SAM.gov](https://sam.gov)*

3 Identify Your NAICS Codes

North American Industry Classification System codes define your business type. Agencies use them to find vendors. Select all codes that accurately describe your products or services.

■ *Tip: Use the NAICS code lookup at census.gov to find the best fit*

4 Apply for Small Business Certifications

SBA certifications — 8(a), HUBZone, SDVOSB, WOSB — unlock set-aside contracts reserved exclusively for qualifying businesses, dramatically improving your win rate.

■ *Opportunity: 23% of federal contracts are legally reserved for small businesses*

5 Understand the FAR

The Federal Acquisition Regulation governs all federal procurement. Master key concepts: contract types (FFP, T&M, CPFF), compliance requirements, and proposal rules.

■ *Free resource: acquisition.gov has the full FAR; [SBA.gov](https://sba.gov) offers plain-language guides*

6 Search for Opportunities on SAM.gov

[SAM.gov](https://sam.gov) lists all federal contract opportunities over \$25,000. Filter by NAICS code, agency, set-aside type, and location. Set up email alerts for relevant solicitations.

■ *Also check: USASpending.gov for historical awards to study agency buying patterns*

7 Conduct Market Research & Target Agencies

Focus on 2–3 agencies that regularly buy what you sell. Review their procurement histories, budget cycles, and small business goals. Build relationships before a solicitation drops.

■ *Strategy: Attend agency industry days and small business outreach events*

8 Write a Capability Statement

Your one-page government resume. Include core competencies, past performance, differentiators, NAICS codes, UEI, and certifications. Tailor it to each target agency.

■ *Format: 1 page, PDF, concise and scannable — your #1 marketing document*

9 Respond to Sources Sought & RFIs

Before formal solicitations, agencies issue Sources Sought notices and Requests for Information. Responding positions you as an interested vendor and can shape future requirements.

■ *Why it matters: RFI responses help agencies determine whether a set-aside is appropriate*

10 Submit Your First Proposal

When you find a good fit, bid on it. Follow every solicitation instruction exactly — proposals are often disqualified on technicalities. Address all evaluation criteria clearly.

■ *Pro tip: Start with contracts under \$250K to build your past performance record*

Free Help Available:

The **Procurement Technical Assistance Center (PTAC)** network offers free one-on-one coaching to help businesses win government contracts. Find your local center at aptac.org. Your local **SBA district office** also provides free resources and referrals.